

1. What is Aesthetics?

- **Aesthetics** is the study of **beauty, art, sensory experience, and judgment**.
- According to **Alexander Gottlieb Baumgarten**, aesthetics is the **science of sensible knowledge**.
- Its aim is:
 - **Beauty** = perfection of sensory knowing
 - **Ugliness** = imperfection

Viva answer (1 line):

Aesthetics studies how we understand beauty, art, and pleasure through our senses.

2. Edmund Burke — Main Idea

- In **1757**, Burke wrote **A Philosophical Inquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful**.
- He separated **beauty** and **the sublime**.
- Influenced by **John Locke** — knowledge comes through the **senses**.

Viva answer:

Burke says our senses shape our understanding of beauty, taste, and the sublime.

3. Taste (Very Important)

Burke defines **taste** as:

the faculty of mind that is affected by, or judges, works of imagination and art.

Burke says taste has 3 parts

A. The Senses

- Basic source of pleasure and pain.
- Human beings generally share similar sensory responses.

Example:

Honey tastes sweet, vinegar tastes sour.

B. Imagination

- Imagination **cannot create totally new things.**
- It only **rearranges ideas already received from the senses.**
- Connected with:
 - fear
 - hope
 - pleasure
 - pain

C. Judgment

- Helps us notice **differences, compare things**
Judgment improves through:
 - knowledge
 - observation
 - practice

Easy viva line

Taste comes from the senses, imagination, and judgment.

4. Burke's idea of Beauty

Burke says beauty creates **love or affection.**

Beauty is associated with:

- **smallness**
- **smoothness**
- **delicate**
- **brightness**
- **Gradual variations**
- **Gracefulness**
- **soft texture**

- pleasant sound or smell
 - Touch
 - Beautiful eyes
-

Important point:

Burke says **beauty is NOT based on proportion or usefulness or perfection**

Example:

A pig's nose may be useful, but not beautiful.

Very short viva answer

Beauty creates affection and is linked with softness, smoothness, delicacy, and smallness.

5. The Sublime (Very Very Important)

Burke's famous idea:

Whatever creates ideas of pain, danger, terror, or fear can produce the sublime.

Sublime creates:

- Terror
- Fear
- Danger
- Obscure
- Hardwork
- Astonishment silence
- Self deprivation
- Succession and uniformity
- Into the play of light and dark

- power : infinity
 - Unsetting
 - Vastness
 - Obstruct
-

Key idea

The sublime gives **delight**, not direct pain.

Why?

Because we enjoy terrifying things **only when we are safe**.

Example:

- storm at sea
 - huge mountains
 - darkness
 - infinity
 - tragic art
-

Simple viva answer

The sublime is a powerful feeling of terror, awe, or greatness that gives delight without actual danger.

6. Difference Between Beauty and Sublime

Beauty	Sublime
Small	Vast
Gentle	Powerful
Pleasing	Terrifying
Produces love	Produces awe/fear

Soft and
delicate

Great and overwhelming

Best viva line

Beauty pleases us; the sublime overwhelms us.

7. Pleasure and Pain

Burke says there are different pleasures:

A. Pleasure in beauty

- calm
- positive
- gentle

B. Pleasure in sublime

- mixed with fear
 - stronger than beauty
 - called **delight**
-

Important viva point

Burke thinks **pain and danger can create stronger emotions than ordinary pleasure.**

8. Why do people have different tastes?

Burke says **basic human taste is similar**, but differences happen because of:

- different knowledge
- experience
- observation

- habit
-

Famous idea

Difference in taste comes more from difference in knowledge than from natural difference.

Easy viva answer

People differ in taste because they have different experiences and knowledge.

9. Quick Examples You Can Mention in Viva

Beauty

- flower
- smooth skin
- soft voice
- graceful movement

Sublime

- thunderstorm
 - ocean at night
 - mountains
 - infinity
 - tragedy
-

10. 5 Super Important One-Liners (Memorize These)

1. Taste is the faculty of judging art and imagination.

2. Beauty creates love or affection.

3. The sublime is connected with terror, danger, and awe.

4. Beauty is gentle; sublime is overwhelming.

5. Difference in taste comes from difference in knowledge.

=====

1. Caged Bird — Maya Angelou

Main Idea

The poem contrasts a **free bird** and a **caged bird**.

- The **free bird** symbolizes:
 - freedom
 - privilege
 - opportunity
- The **caged bird** symbolizes:
 - oppression
 - racism
 - restriction
 - suffering

The poem is linked to the history of **Jim Crow laws**.

Important Symbols

Free Bird

- flies in the sky

- enjoys nature
- chooses where to go
- represents liberty

Caged Bird

- trapped behind bars
 - wings clipped
 - feet tied
 - cannot move freely
-

Important Idea

Even though the caged bird is trapped, **it still sings**.

That song represents:

- hope
 - resistance
 - longing for freedom
-

Very Important Lines

“The caged bird sings of freedom.”

This means:

Even oppressed people continue to dream of freedom.

Themes

- freedom vs oppression
 - racial injustice
 - hope
 - resilience
 - human dignity
-

Easy Viva Answer

The poem shows that freedom belongs naturally to everyone, but oppression cannot destroy the desire for freedom.

2. Identity Card — Mahmoud Darwish

Main Idea

The speaker repeatedly says:

“Put it on record, I am an Arab.”

The poem is about:

- identity
 - dignity
 - dispossession
 - anger against injustice
 - Palestinian resistance
-

What the speaker says

He tells the authorities:

- he is Arab
 - he has a family
 - he works hard
 - he asks for no charity
 - his roots are ancient
-

Important Idea

The speaker's land has been taken away.

He says:

- vineyards were stolen
- land was stolen
- only rocks were left

This reflects the **Palestinian struggle**.

Tone of the poem

The tone is:

- proud
 - firm
 - angry
 - resistant
-

Key Symbol

Identity card

Represents:

- political control
- surveillance
- forced labeling

But the speaker turns it into a declaration of identity.

Very Important Lines

“I am an Arab.”

This is not only information — it is an act of resistance.

Themes

- identity
 - homeland
 - resistance
 - injustice
 - anger
 - dignity
-

Easy Viva Answer

The poem is a powerful declaration of Palestinian identity and protest against dispossession.

Comparison of Both Poems

Caged Bird	Identity Card
about freedom and oppression	about identity and dispossession
symbolic language	direct political voice
personal suffering represents many people	speaker directly represents his people
hope through song	resistance through speech

Quick 6 One-Liners for Viva

1.

The free bird represents freedom.

2.

The caged bird represents oppression.

3.

The caged bird sings because hope survives oppression.

4.

“I am an Arab” is a statement of identity and resistance.

5.

Darwish’s poem protests loss of land and dignity.

6.

Both poems speak for oppressed people.



Literature for Life – Easy Viva Notes

◆ 1. Edmund Burke – Sublime & Beautiful

✓ Core Idea (Easy)

- Humans feel things in similar ways.
 - Two types of feelings:
 - **Sublime** = fear + awe (big, powerful things)
 - **Beautiful** = love + pleasure (small, soft things)
-

◆ Sublime (VERY IMPORTANT)

- Comes from **fear + danger**
- Examples: storm, ocean, darkness
- Feels **powerful + overwhelming**
- Enjoyable only when **safe distance**

👉 Example: Watching horror movie = fun (not real danger)

♦ Beautiful

- Comes from **love + attraction**
- Features:
 - small
 - smooth
 - soft
 - delicate

👉 Example: baby, flowers

♦ Taste (Simple)

- Taste = **sense + imagination + judgment**
 - Everyone has same basic taste
 - Difference comes from **education & experience**
-

♦ Key Idea

- Sublime = strong emotion (fear)
 - Beautiful = gentle emotion (love)
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♦ 2. Folk Music – Bob Dylan & Lalon Fakir

✅ Core Idea

- Folk music = **voice of common people**
 - Used for:
 - protest
 - truth
 - identity
-

♦ Bob Dylan

- Spoke about:
 - racism

- war
 - injustice
 - Songs ask questions (not direct answers)
-

♦ Lalon Fakir

- Said:
 - no caste
 - no religion division
 - Belief: **God is inside humans**
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♦ Key Features

- Simple language
 - Repetition
 - Deep meaning
 - Sung, not just written
-

♦ Important Idea

👉 Music can influence people faster than speech

♦ 3. Slavery + “Caged Bird”

✅ Core Idea

- Black people faced:
 - slavery
 - racism
 - segregation
 - Still resisted through culture
-

♦ Free Bird vs Caged Bird

Free Bird Caged Bird

Freedom No freedom

Flies Trapped

Happy Suffering

♦ Main Message

- Even if body is trapped → **spirit is free**
 - The bird **still sings**
-

♦ Key Idea

👉 Singing = resistance

♦ 4. “Bidrohi” – Kazi Nazrul Islam

✅ Core Idea

- Total rebellion against everything
 - Not asking for freedom → **declaring it**
-

♦ Key Features

- Uses many mythological names
 - Shows:
 - power
 - anger
 - energy
-

♦ Important Idea

- Rebel = both:

- creator
 - destroyer
-

◆ Ending Meaning

👉 Rebel will rest only when **justice exists**

◆ 5. Birangona (1971 War Women)

✅ Core Idea

- Women were raped during war
 - Called “heroine” but treated badly by society
-

◆ Reality

- Society:
 - rejected them
 - blamed them
 - They suffered twice:
 - war
 - society
-

◆ Fatema

- Strong survivor
 - Lives for revenge and survival
-

◆ Meher Jan

- Smart + practical
 - Builds her own life
 - Becomes independent
-

◆ Key Idea

👉 They are NOT victims only → they are **fighters**

◆ 6. Important Themes (VERY IMPORTANT FOR VIVA)

◆ 1. Body

- Burke → feelings from body
 - Caged Bird → body trapped
 - Birangona → body used in war
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◆ 2. Voice

- Caged bird sings
- Birangona tells story
- Folk songs spread truth

👉 Voice = power

◆ 3. Freedom

- Not just legal freedom
 - Need:
 - respect
 - rights
 - dignity
-

◆ 4. Personal = Political

- Personal pain connects to society